

Structure – Active and Passive Structures. When the subject of a sentence represents the doer of an action, the verb of the

predicate is in the active voice. When the subject of a sentence represents the

sufferer of the action, the verb of the predicate is in the passive voice. More often than not, verbs are used in the active, and less frequently in the passive

Examples

Active Passive

Chike broke the plate The plate was broken by Chike

The workers swept the streets The streets were swept by the workers. Nkechi ate the food The food was eaten by Nkechi

When changing Active to Passive, the following must be noted:

Only transitive verbs (i.e. verbs that receive objects can be used in the passive). This implies that the active sentence has an object that becomes the subject of

the passive sentence

The tense of the transitive verb in the active sentence determines the tense of be

in the passive sentence. The preposition 'by' is introduced in the passive sentence. (not in all

cases except

when absolutely necessary). Note that not all active sentences can be changed to passive because the passive

form has its proper place and function in English. Consider the following

Sentences with transitive verb:

Ada travelled with Obi to Enugu

She slept for a whole day. Sentences with linking verbs. He became a lawyer

You friend seems a very nice person.

Sentences with special transitive verbs like the following:

They have a new house. The new dress fits the girl. She resembles her mother. The passive form should not be seen simply as an alternative to the active form. The

main reason for using the passive is used

To give due emphasis to the verb activity rather than the active subject:

Coal is mined at Enugu.

'Things Fall Apart' was written in the 1950's

When the doer of the action is not known. He was killed during the war.